

The Bard's love story and a Shakespearean twist

Like any good Shakespearean **revelation**, this comes not with **thunder and lightning**, but in ink and **parchment**. A **crumbling** letter has **upended** one of **literary** history's long-held assumptions — that William Shakespeare **abandoned** his wife Anne Hathaway in Stratford-upon-Avon while he **made his fortune** in London. Analysed by professor Matthew Steggle of the University of Bristol, the **fragment** found in the binding of a book in Hereford Cathedral's library and **addressed** to "Good Mrs Shakspeare" suggests Anne may have been far more present in his life than the **myth** of the **forsaken provincial** wife allows: It is an appeal to her by a London **widow** to repay the money **entrusted** to Shakespeare by her husband.

Biographers have **chipped away** at Anne's agency over the centuries. She has been **cast** variously as a supportive wife **bringing up** their three children in the **countryside** while running the family **brewery**, a woman of **weary estrangement**, a **harriidan** who forced Shakespeare into marriage because she was pregnant with their child. But what if Shakespeare's creative life and their marriage weren't **at odds**? What if Anne was Sonnet 137's "fair truth" — not an absence in his story, but its quiet **anchor**? In his **will**, Shakespeare had **bequeathed** "...my **second best bed** with **the furniture**" to Anne, **interpreted** by later scholars as a **snub**. But in the Elizabethan world, the second-best, **often** the marital bed, symbolised **fidelity**; the "best" was usually kept in the guest room as a status symbol.



From Viola to Portia to even Lady Macbeth, Shakespeare's heroines were women of agency and **complexity**. His domestic story may lack the **sweep** of legend, but it may have been something richer — a partnership **sturdy** enough to survive separation, **sonnets** and **speculation**. [\[Practice Exercise\]](#)

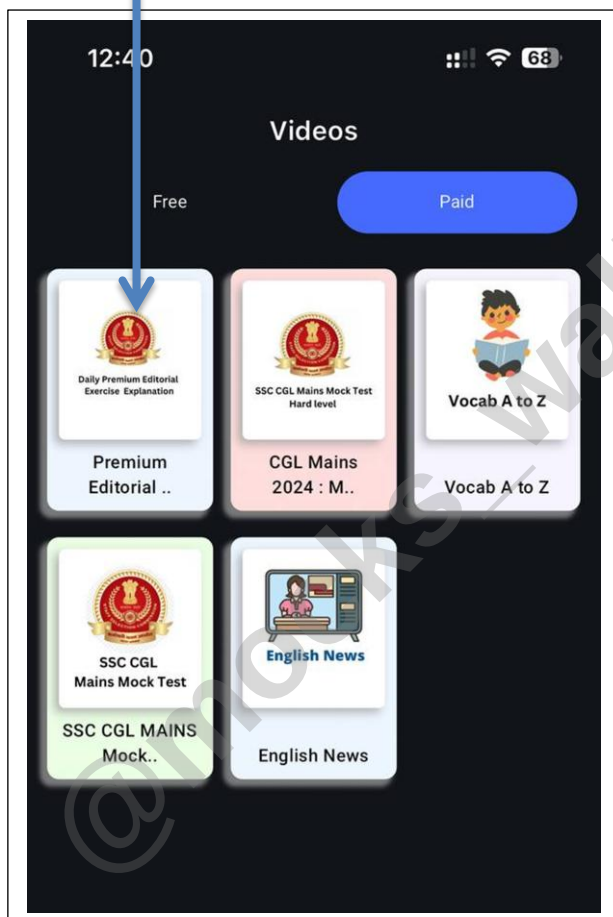
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Revelation** (noun) – disclosure, discovery, unveiling, epiphany, insight खुलासा
2. **Thunder and lightning** (noun) – storm, uproar, turmoil, drama, commotion गरज और चमक / नाटकीय स्थिति
3. **Parchment** (noun) – manuscript, scroll, vellum, document, paper पुराना कागज़
4. **Crumbling** (adjective) – decaying, falling apart, deteriorating, fragmenting, breaking down टूटता हुआ
5. **Upend** (verb) – overturn, disrupt, reverse, unsettle, topple उलट देना
6. **Literary** (adjective) – bookish, written, textual, poetic, scholarly साहित्यिक
7. **Abandon** (verb) – leave, forsake, desert, discard, renounce छोड़ देना
8. **Make one's fortune** (phrase) – become wealthy, succeed, prosper, thrive, achieve success सफल होना
9. **Fragment** (noun) – piece, shard, scrap, remnant, chunk अंश
10. **Address** (verb) – direct, write to, speak to, refer, appeal to संबोधित करना
11. **Myth** (noun) – legend, false belief, misconception, tale, folklore मिथक
12. **Forsaken** (adjective) – abandoned, deserted, neglected, rejected, forlorn त्यागा हुआ
13. **Provincial** (adjective) – rural, regional, countryside, local, rustic ग्रामीण
14. **Widow** (noun) – woman whose spouse has died, bereaved wife, lone woman विधवा
15. **Entrust** (verb) – assign, delegate, hand over, confide, consign सौंपना
16. **Chip away** (phrasal verb) – erode, diminish, wear down, gradually remove, undermine धीरे-धीरे हटाना / कम करना
17. **Cast** (verb) – portray, depict, represent, describe, characterize प्रस्तुत करना
18. **Bring up** (phrasal verb) – raise, nurture, rear, care for, educate पालना
19. **Countryside** (noun) – rural area, farmland, village, landscape, province ग्रामीण क्षेत्र / देहात
20. **Brewery** (noun) – beer factory, alehouse, distillery, brewing place शराब बनाने की जगह
21. **Weary** (adjective) – tired, fatigued, exhausted, worn out, drained थका हुआ

22. **Estrangement** (noun) – alienation, separation, detachment, isolation, disconnection अलगाव
23. **Harridan** (noun) – shrew, nag, scold, termagant, ill-tempered woman झगड़ालू औरत
24. **At odds** (phrase) – in conflict, inconsistent, in disagreement, opposed, clashing विरोध में
25. **Anchor** (noun) – support, foundation, stabilizer, root, mainstay आधार / स्थिरता देने वाला
26. **Will** (noun) – legal document, testament, bequest, final wishes, legacy वसीयत
27. **Bequeath** (verb) – leave, pass on, hand down, grant, bestow वसीयत करना / छोड़ जाना
28. **Second best bed** (noun) – marital bed, symbolic gift, shared bed, reserved bed, spousal bed वैवाहिक बिस्तर
29. **The furniture** (noun) – "furniture" in this context refers to the bed curtains and bedcover
30. **Interpret** (verb) – explain, understand, analyze, perceive, clarify अर्थ निकालना
31. **Snub** (noun) – insult, slight, cold shoulder, rebuff, humiliation तिरस्कार / अपमान
32. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, many times, commonly, usually अक्सर
33. **Fidelity** (noun) – faithfulness, loyalty, devotion, trustworthiness, commitment निष्ठा / वफादारी
34. **Complexity** (noun) – intricacy, complication, depth, richness, sophistication जटिलता
35. **Sweep** (noun) – range, breadth, scope, extent, span विस्तार / फैलाव
36. **Sturdy** (adjective) – strong, solid, resilient, durable, tough मजबूत / टिकाऊ
37. **Sonnet** (noun) – poem, verse, lyric, composition, rhyme चौदह पंक्तियों की कविता
38. **Speculation** (noun) – conjecture, guesswork, theory, assumption, hypothesis अनुमान

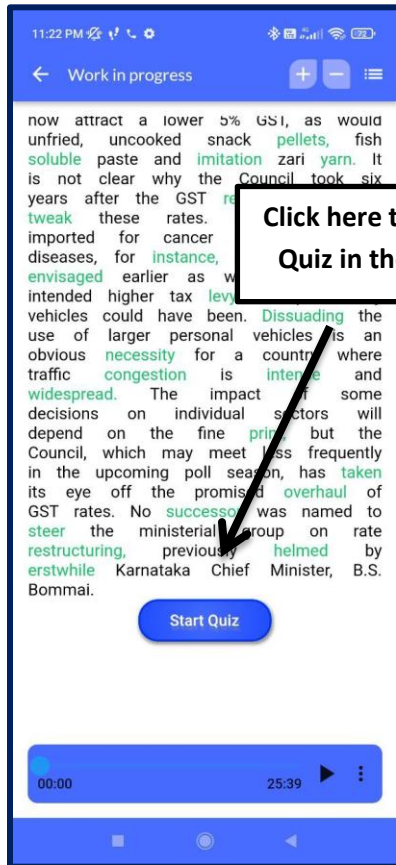
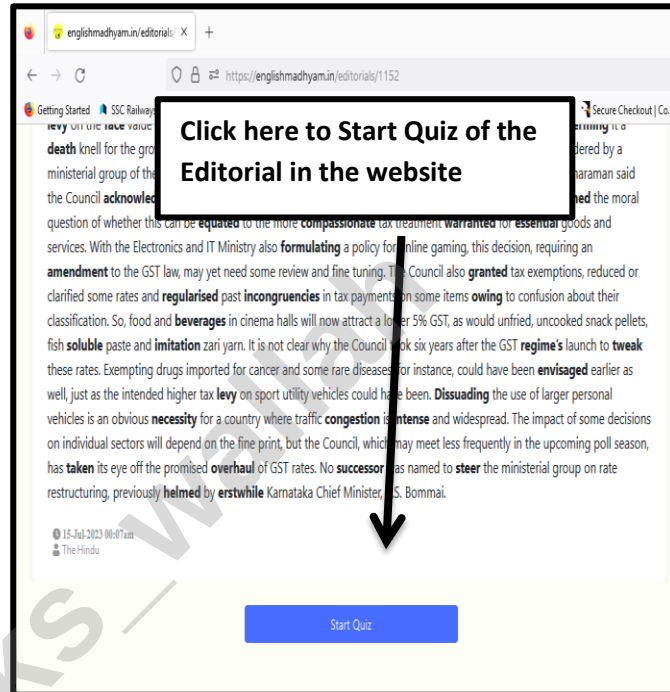
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



Summary of the Editorial

1. A newly discovered letter has **challenged the long-standing belief** that William Shakespeare abandoned his wife, Anne Hathaway.
2. The **letter was found in a book binding** at Hereford Cathedral's library.
3. It was addressed to "**Good Mrs Shakspeare**" and involves a debt repayment issue.
4. The content **suggests Anne was actively involved in Shakespeare's life**, contrary to the popular myth of her being forsaken.
5. The letter indicates **Anne had financial and personal ties to Shakespeare's London life**.
6. Historically, biographers have portrayed Anne as **marginalized or estranged** from Shakespeare.
7. She has variously been described as **a supportive wife, a nagging partner, or a reluctant bride**.
8. The editorial questions the assumption that **Shakespeare's artistic life was incompatible with a fulfilling marriage**.
9. It speculates that Anne may have been the **muse or subject of Sonnet 137**, referred to as "fair truth".
10. Shakespeare's will, often interpreted as a slight to Anne by leaving her the "second-best bed", may actually **symbolize intimacy and fidelity**.
11. In Elizabethan culture, the **second-best bed was typically the marital bed**, while the best was reserved for guests.
12. This reinterpretation invites a **reconsideration of Anne's role** in Shakespeare's personal and creative life.
13. Shakespeare's **female characters were strong, nuanced, and complex**, possibly reflecting the real women in his life.
14. The article suggests Shakespeare and Anne's marriage may have been a **quiet, enduring partnership**, rather than a tale of neglect.
15. Ultimately, the editorial offers a **richer, more human view** of Shakespeare's domestic life — full of love, collaboration, and subtle strength.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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